

T H E

Prenatal Protocol

N O U R I S H . P R O T E C T . G R O W .

B Y

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GUTGURU PROTOCOL

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CHAPTER 01

Critical Prenatal Nutrients

The first 12 weeks of pregnancy are the most nutritionally critical — organ formation begins before most women know they're pregnant.



Folate / Vitamin B9

The neural tube closes by Week 4. Folate deficiency before this window causes neural tube defects — which is why pre-conception folate matters.



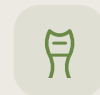
Iron for Blood Volume

Blood volume increases by 50% in pregnancy. Iron deficiency anaemia in pregnancy is linked to preterm birth, low birth weight, and maternal fatigue.



DHA (Omega-3)

DHA is the primary structural fat in the foetal brain and retina. Adequate DHA in pregnancy is associated with higher cognitive scores in children.

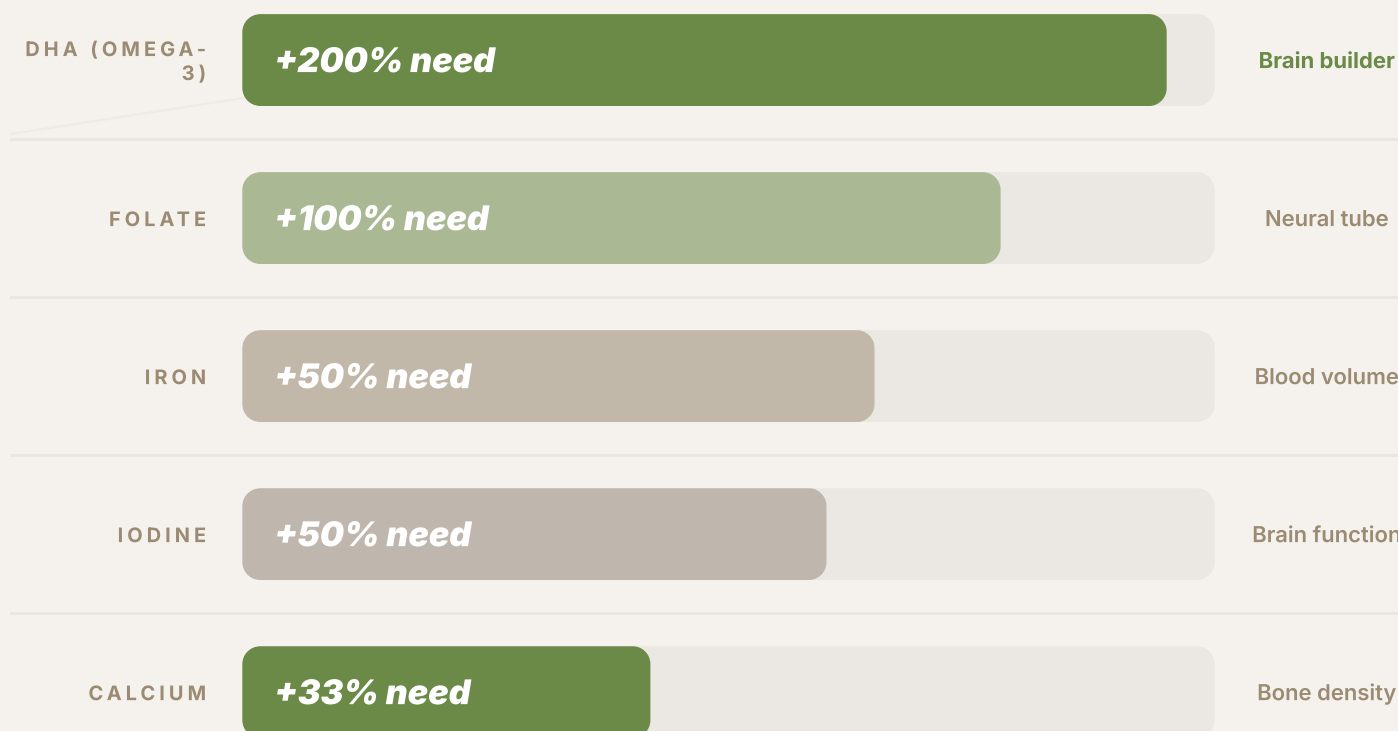


Iodine

Iodine deficiency during pregnancy is the world's leading preventable cause of intellectual disability. Thyroid hormones require iodine for foetal brain development.

CHAPTER 02

Nutrient Needs *Increase* in Pregnancy



DHA requirements double in pregnancy — yet it is the nutrient most commonly deficient in Indian women, who eat little fatty fish. Flaxseed and walnuts offer plant-based ALA, though conversion to DHA is limited.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Start folate before conception — not after a positive test. The neural tube closes at week 4, before many women know they are pregnant. Methi, chana, and palak are excellent food sources.

CHAPTER 03

Prioritise vs Avoid

Food safety matters as much as nutrition during pregnancy — certain foods carry infection or toxicity risks to the foetus.

PRIORITISE

Nutrient-Dense Choices

These deliver folate, iron, DHA, calcium, and iodine — the most critical prenatal nutrients.

Palak / methi

Rajma / chana

Rohu / pomfret fish

Eggs (fully cooked)

Milk + curd

Ragi

Walnuts

Dates

Moringa

Amla

AVOID

Risky in Pregnancy

These carry infection, heavy metal, or hormonal risks to foetal development.

Raw papaya

Pineapple (large amounts)

Unpasteurised dairy

Raw / undercooked eggs

High-mercury fish (shark, swordfish)

Alcohol

Excess caffeine (>200mg)

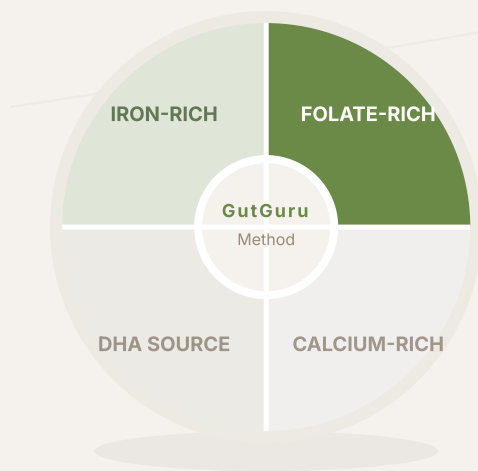
Raw sprouts

Fully cooked pomfret and rohu are safe, low-mercury fish — and excellent DHA sources that are entirely appropriate in Indian pregnancy diets.

CHAPTER 04

The Prenatal Plate Formula

THE GUTGURU PREGNANCY NUTRITION METHOD

**Folate-Rich Foods**

Palak, chana, rajma, methi, broccoli

+

**Iron-Rich Foods**

Rajma, ragi, dates, moringa, liver (if non-veg)

+

**DHA Sources**

Rohu, pomfret, walnuts, flaxseed (2×/week)

+

**Calcium Sources**

Milk, curd, ragi, sesame seeds, paneer

EXAMPLE MEAL

Ragi mudde + rajma + palak sabzi + curd + walnuts**T1: +0 kcal · T2: +340 kcal · T3: +450 kcal**

ADDITIONAL DAILY CALORIES BY TRIMESTER

CHAPTER 05

Common *Prenatal* Mistakes

**Not starting folate before conception**

The neural tube — which becomes the brain and spinal cord — closes at week 4. Pre-conception folate is the only way to fully protect this window.

**Doubling food intake from week 1**

Additional calories are only needed from the second trimester (+340 kcal/day). T1 requires nutritional quality, not quantity.

**Avoiding all seafood to be safe**

2 servings/week of low-mercury fish (rohu, pomfret) are recommended in pregnancy for DHA — complete seafood avoidance creates a deficiency.

**Eating raw papaya or drinking aloe vera juice**

Raw papaya contains papain which stimulates uterine contractions. Aloe vera in large amounts is also contraindicated.

**Assuming the prenatal vitamin "covers everything"**

Supplements don't replace whole foods — iron from food is absorbed differently to supplements, and food provides co-factors supplements lack.

CHAPTER 06

Quick Myth Busters

MYTH You must avoid all seafood during pregnancy.

TRUTH **2 servings/week of low-mercury fish (pomfret, rohu, salmon) is the clinical recommendation** — providing DHA critical for foetal brain development.

MYTH Eating for two means doubling your food from the start.

TRUTH **The first trimester requires no extra calories — only quality.** Additional calories are needed from the second trimester onward (+340–450 kcal/day).

MYTH Herbal teas are safe in pregnancy since they're natural.

TRUTH **Many herbs are contraindicated in pregnancy** — including large amounts of tulsi, ashwagandha, aloe vera, and fenugreek. "Natural" does not mean safe.

TAKE THIS HOME

Your 3 Quick Wins

Three specific actions you can start this week — no equipment, no cost, measurable results.

1

Add a Folate-Rich Food to Breakfast Every Day

Add **palak, methi, or chana to your breakfast** every single day. Palak paratha, methi dal, or chana salad all deliver the folate most critical in the first trimester. If you are planning conception, begin now — not after a positive test.

STARTING TODAY

2

Add 1 Tablespoon of Flaxseed to Your Daily Curd

Add **1 tbsp of ground flaxseed to your curd or smoothie** every day for plant-based omega-3 (ALA). This is the most accessible DHA precursor in an Indian vegetarian diet — cheap, flavourless, and takes 5 seconds.

ONCE DAILY, EVERY DAY

3

Test Your Iron and Folate Levels This Week

Ask for a complete blood count + serum ferritin + folate test this week. Many pregnancy complications begin with deficiencies that were present months before they were detected. Knowing your numbers now gives you time to correct them.

IF NOT TESTED IN THE LAST 3 MONTHS

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READY TO PERSONALIZE?

Book a 1-on-1 Consultation

Get a clinical nutrition plan tailored to your prenatal nutrition,
body, and lifestyle.

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